Owning India's Electrons

A Citizen's Note on Digital Thorium

Abhilash Inumella · Anubhav Tiwari · April 2026

My grandfather kept his savings in gold. My father kept his savings in property. I do not yet know what to do with mine, and that is what this short note is about.

The world my grandfather lived in rewarded gold because the rupee was unstable. The world my father lived in rewarded land because India was urbanising faster than the supply of plots. The world I live in is different from both. Gold no longer outpaces real inflation by much. Land in most Indian metros has plateaued. The salaried child of an Indian family today, whether in Patna or Pune, does not know where to put their savings, because the two answers that worked for the previous two generations are no longer obviously the right answers for the next thirty years.

There is a third answer becoming available, and it sits on two facts.

The first is that India holds approximately 846,000 tonnes of thorium, roughly a quarter of the world's known supply. The Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor at Kalpakkam went critical in April 2026, closing the last engineering gap in a programme Homi Bhabha first proposed in 1954. India is the only country in the world that has spent seventy years patiently assembling the thorium fuel cycle.

The second is that the world's appetite for electricity is about to triple. The International Energy Agency projects global data centre demand to rise from 415 terawatt-hours in 2024 to nearly 2,000 terawatt-hours by 2035. Every AI query, every model training run, every automated business process consumes electricity, somewhere, in a windowless building, day and night. The country that supplies cheap clean baseload to this demand becomes the home of the world's compute. The country that does not becomes its customer.

What is being proposed is a way for ordinary Indians to own a slice of this convergence. The instrument is called Digital Thorium. The government would create a statutory corporation, the National Thorium Finance Corporation, which buys the rights to a fraction of the electricity produced by specific reactor cohorts and sells those rights to retail savers in small slices. Each slice represents a claim on a kilowatt-hour-year of output. The minimum ticket is INR 500, the same as the cheapest mutual fund SIP. Every ninety days the holder receives their share of the cash the reactor earned by selling electrons to the grid.

The arithmetic is straightforward. INR 10,000 invested today, held for twenty years in the central case, becomes approximately INR 1.5 lakh, of which INR 36,000 arrives as quarterly cash distributions over the holding period and the rest as appreciation in the secondary market value of the slice. A monthly SIP of INR 5,000 starting at age twenty-five and continuing to retirement at sixty accumulates approximately four crore in current rupees, compared to roughly two crore in a Nifty index fund and sixty-five lakh in a bank fixed deposit.

These figures are not promises. They depend on the central case holding: reactor cohorts coming online on schedule, AI demand growing roughly as projected, the political durability of the statutory framework. Each of these can disappoint. In the worst plausible scenario, the holder still earns roughly bank fixed deposit returns on a productive real asset. The underlying is electricity that real customers buy with real money, so the floor is not zero.

What makes the instrument unusual is not the return, which is real but not magic. It is the combination of features. It is the only retail-accessible instrument with sovereign backing, positive correlation to AI compute demand, and a productive real asset underlying it. Gold pays nothing while it appreciates. Land is stuck in one place. Fixed deposits barely keep up with inflation. Equity is a bet on many things at once. Digital Thorium is a clean expression of a single thesis: that India's electron output, financed by Indian savings, will power Indian intelligence in the coming forty years.

This is not investment advice. The instrument has not launched. The proposal would have to pass Parliament, with implementing regulations from SEBI and the Reserve Bank. Final terms will be set in cohort-specific prospectuses. Before committing savings to any new instrument, please read the relevant prospectus and consider your own circumstances.

But the choice is worth thinking about now, because the choice is not just personal. It is about what kind of country the saver wants to fund. Today, much of the Indian middle class's accumulated savings finances second flats in already-saturated neighbourhoods and gold sitting in lockers. Tomorrow, those savings could finance the largest clean baseload build-out in human history, owned by the people who live in the country it powers.

My grandfather kept his savings in gold because the rupee did not yet trust itself. My father kept his savings in land because the country was urbanising. When my daughter is twenty-five and asks me what I did with mine, I would like to be able to tell her that I bought a small slice of a reactor that powered a piece of the country she was born into. Not because the slice made me rich, though I hope it did. Because the slice was the rational answer to a country that was becoming itself, and I did not want her to grow up in a country whose electrons were owned somewhere else.

That is the citizen's case. The rest is arithmetic.